



PASSIONATE: A TRS public rally at Warangal; youth showing their support for the movement (below)

jolt the Congress calculations for the Lok Sabha and assembly elections. And the Congress action when four MPs led by Rao gave their resignations on the floor of the Lok Sabha certainly vindicates that. It cancelled a massive rally to be addressed by Sonia in Hyderabad on March 14, conceding a moral victory to TRS.

A reality-check in the state shows Congress a divided house on the issue of Telangana. Sections of its district-level leaders in the region are backing, though not overtly, the demand for a separate state. Says AICC secretary and Nizamabad MP Madhu Goud Yashki, "Telangana is no longer a sentimental or a development issue but a question of self-respect, self-rule and governance for the people of the region." Defending his Government on the issue, Chief Minister Y.S.

Rajasekhara Reddy says, "We are not saying that there is no sentiment for Telangana but it is not in the hands of the Congress alone. No consensus has been reached on the issue yet."

Equally split is the main regional party TDP. Claims T. Devender Goud, deputy leader of TDP in the state legislative assembly, "The party is facing some problems and that is why I am restraining myself now. If I make up my mind and start touring the Telangana districts, people will not allow Congress leaders, including the chief minister, into their villages." While some in the party from the region have kept silent, the rest of TDP, including party president N. Chandrababu Naidu, are opposed to the division of the state.

Given the internal churn in the Congress and TDP, the TRS calculation is that their strategy of applying pressure

through resignations will yield positive results and force the UPA Government into action. At the same time, it is acutely aware that but for this dramatic act, there is very little it can do. The party faces a challenge in that there are no indications that it enjoys support, cutting across political parties, on the issue of statehood. Only BJP and the Maoists have come out openly in favour of a Telangana state while CPI has only indicated that it is not wholly opposed to the idea.

In building up its support base, TRS has been found wanting when it comes to fundamental issues like planning, strategy and direction, even if it may have raised awareness about the issue through resignations. Rao's autocratic ways are not acceptable to many in his party, but few, if any, doubt his dogged determination to achieve his goal. It is this resolve coupled with the organisational skills of TRS activists



TRS hopes the resignation strategy will pay off with increased support from the youth.

that will help the party galvanise the groundswell of support. They also hope to prove that the demand for statehood is more real than imagined and is not just an undercurrent of resentment limited to a few. For the moment though, the party's success lies in having rattled the Congress enough to take a stand on, rather than evade, the issue. ■